



DAVID SHAW
JUNE 9TH, 2023



AMUSE BOUCHE

Hokkaido scallop crudo
served with champagne sauce, cauliflower and cauliflower purée

BREAD SELECTION

Focaccia, Grissini, Carta di Musica, and Parmigiano Breadstick

BEEF CONSOMMÉ

Tagliolini and green asparagus, “Taiyouran” egg yolk

CONFIT ABALONE CARPACCIO

Sweet pepper and semi-dried tomato, Oscietra caviar, abalone liver sauce

BRITTANY BLUE LOBSTER

White asparagus and lobster jus

SHORT RIB & BEEF TENDERLOIN

Braised short rib and medium rare tenderloin from Mayura beef farm
served with whipped potatoes, red wine and plum sauce, seasonal vegetables

FINE CHEESE SELECTION
FROM OUR AGING ROOM

Served with homemade raisin on vine and berry compote

Tuma dla Paja

La Tur

Losa

Comté 48 months aged

Muffato

LIMONCELLO SOUFFLÉ

Citrus salad and lemon gelato

PETIT FOURS TROLLEY

Selections of petit sweets



With my previous experience at Otto e Mezzo Shanghai four years ago being rather buttoned-down, my expectation for this flagship establishment were never set too high. Booking almost last-minute, we do not anticipate anything extraordinary or surprising; nonetheless, we expect a somewhat decent and relaxing dinner from this three-Michelin-starred restaurant. Having already enjoyed a marvelous lunch at Amber earlier that day, our stomachs are prepared for only a light treat. As dinner time approaches, we leisurely arrive at the front door of Otto e Mezzo. Crossing the somewhat tiny and inconspicuous threshold, a lively yet cozy bar area unfolds before us. After a prompt confirmation with the front desk, we are finally ushered into the quiet and elegant main dining space. The maitre d' kindly offers us one of the best seats in the place—a spacious round corner table. However, the servers, a group mainly consisting of mid-aged gentlemen in business suits, seem unpleasantly cold and dismissive.

A three-Michelin-starred restaurant featuring an à la carte menu is the perfect setting for a leisurely dinner. Given the limited yet thoughtfully curated menu, we opted for something classic. As we finalized our selections, a straightforward amuse-bouche graced our table — a Hokkaido scallop crudo accompanied by a champagne sauce, cauliflower, and cauliflower purée. How interesting it is to embark on an Italian dining journey with Japanese scallops and a French sauce. The only truly Italian element seemed to be the name ‘crudo’ per se. Garnished with parsley and chives, the crudo exuded an herbal fragrance, heightened by the addition of caviar, which brought forth oceanic salinity. The champagne sauce offered an essential acidity, though mild, that awakened the palate. It also contributed a creamy, silky texture that harmonized the dish, together with the cauliflower purée. While the crudo proved to be a standard dish, lacking in surprises, each detail had been meticulously curated, leaving an unmistakable mark of quality.



Following the amuse-bouche, the waiter carelessly presented some bread, served with the standard olive oil and balsamic vinegar duo. Focaccia, Grissini, Carta di Musica, and Parmigiano Breadstick— despite their fancy Italian names — proved to be truly rustic and unrefined. The focaccia, in particular, paled in comparison to what Da Vittorio Shanghai had offered.



Transitioning to the appetizers, we indulge in a beef consommé and a confit abalone carpaccio, both bearing the peculiar influence of French culinary heritage. The consommé, served in an expansive bowl that harmonized with its color palette, presents a clear beef soup featuring an island crafted from tagliolini pasta and adorned with verdant asparagus, all crowned by a distinguished "Taiyouran" egg yolk. While the clear soup may suggest simplicity, its creation demands a meticulous and time-intensive process. This consommé, derives from a sumptuously flavored stock or broth, undergoes a meticulous clarification procedure to eliminate impurities. The method involves simmering the broth with a blend of ground meats, egg whites, and other ingredients, culminating in a strained elixir of clarity and flavor. The renowned "Taiyouran" egg, despite its elevated cost which is mainly because of the augmented levels of Vitamin E compared to standard eggs, does not taste remarkably marvelous. The chef's central concept may involve presenting tagliolini in a clear soup, a departure from the customary practices of Italian cuisine. Yet, the consommé's dominant presence provides reassurance to diners that, despite the Italian pasta presentation, the dish is firmly rooted in the rich tradition of French culinary artistry.



Turning to the confit abalone carpaccio, the thinly sliced abalone aligns with the carpaccio concept, introducing a more pronounced Italian flair than its soupy counterpart. Subjected to the French confit technique, the abalone achieves a sublime tenderness. The addition of sweet pepper and semi-dried tomato imparts a touch of rustic charm, while the inclusion of abalone liver sauce hints at a subtle Japanese inspiration. The flavor profile may not immediately evoke Japanese or French cuisine. In reality, the thinly sliced abalone imparts a distinct, clear texture on the palate, undeniably reminiscent of a traditional Italian carpaccio. Nevertheless, the culinary identity ultimately draws upon its cultural background, and it's inevitable to discern the subtle influence of Japanese and French culinary ideals behind the scenes.



If the appetizers still bear a trace of Italian heritage, the main courses unequivocally reveal the chef's departure from the Italian culinary identity. Prior to arriving at the restaurant, I pondered a question: what distinguishes Italian cuisine from French cuisine when pasta is not in the equation? The answer, it seems, is not much! Italian and French culinary traditions share remarkable similarities, with modern French haute cuisine itself having roots in Italian food. However, Italian cuisine has its distinctive elements, characterized by specific dishes like ossobuco, signature sauces such as Fra Diavolo, and regional styles like Piedmontese, Florentine, and Sicilian. Remarkably, the menu at Otto e Mezzo, despite its vast selection of meat and seafood, lacks a direct adherence to identifiably Italian dishes. The seafood main course we chose, a Brittany blue lobster accompanied by white asparagus and lobster jus, is a pure French creation featuring lobster from France, employing French sauce, and incorporating vegetables favored in French culinary tradition.



From the land, we savored a beef duo featuring braised short rib and medium-rare beef tenderloin sourced from Mayura beef farm. Both are elegantly accompanied by whipped potatoes, a rich red wine and plum sauce, and seasonal vegetables. The dish adheres to tradition without venturing into innovative territory at all, but as someone who appreciates the virtues of classical cuisine, I am not a critique of the restaurant for presenting a more classical approach. I just find it somewhat hilarious for an Italian restaurant to delve so deeply into French culinary influences. Putting this aside, the dish itself underscores a mastery of cooking techniques. The beef duo, prepared through distinct cooking methods, both achieve a state of perfection—tender and succulent. The sauce, with a subtle mellow acidity complementing the traditional red wine glaze, adds another layer of sophistication. However, the vegetables, relegated to the role of side components, unfortunately, lose their vibrancy in the overall presentation.



The arrival of the soufflé reaffirms the restaurant's preference for French cuisine. Despite being infused with the Italian liqueur Limoncello, the overall experience remains quintessentially French in every aspect. In terms of execution, however, it falls short compared to what Caprice offered the other day. The soufflé here presents a more rural mouthfeel, lacking the desired level of airiness to captivate my palate.

For the second dessert course, I eagerly embraced the opportunity for a more authentically Italian experience. Finally, the menu featured an Italian cheese selection. Accompanied by homemade raisins on the vine and a berry compote, I was presented with a delightful array of five Italian cheeses. Among them were the soft and creamy Tuma dla Paja made from sheep's and cow's milk, appreciated for its delicate milky aroma and subtle hazelnut scent; the lesser-known yet super creamy La Tur, crafted from a blend of cow, sheep, and goat milk, boasting a rich buttery aroma with hints of earthy tones and an acidic tang; the semi-matured soft cheese Losa from Piedmont; a precious French Comté cheese aged for 48 months; and finally, the oak-barrel-aged blue-veined cow milk cheese, Muffato. Even within this narrow selection, a French cheese managed to make its way onto the plate.

The lack of coordination among the waitstaff becomes a source of irritation once again. Three different waiters failed to reach a consensus on the correct names of each cheese. It is predictable that a further attempting to glean details about the cheeses could only added to the frustration.

The dinner finally concludes with the arrival of the mignardise carte. Despite being crafted with delicacy, the small bites remain somewhat ordinary and do not leave a lasting impression.

